

Many of the newer digital cameras, and even some mobile phones have an in-built panorama shooting function, but this does not extend to more than three photos, giving a very limited view, and not allowing for an automatic shoot of a 360 degree panorama. It is better to manually shoot 360 degrees and then stitch up the resulting images on a computer.

To shoot a panorama, take around twelve shots after changing an angle of about 30 degrees between shots. It is good to use a tripod, and a protractor too. Get out that geometry box that is collecting dust at the back of your drawer. However, none of these things are essential. You can simply take a good panorama by simply estimating the degrees. A digital camera allows you the luxury of looking at your photo before you take the next photo, so you can get a very fair approximation of where to point next. However, if you are not using a tripod, either take the entire sequence of shots very rapidly, which also helps if you have moving subjects in the frame or make sure that you align the shots using the horizon or some other reference. Getting your photos out of alignment will lead to a panorama like this, which looks pretty ugly.

There will always be some mistakes in the alignment, even if you are using a tripod, so it makes sense to crop out the excess areas using an image manipulation tool. However, don't depend too much on this while capturing a panoramic view.

Now a panorama does not necessarily have to be a landscape from a high altitude. It can be the middle of a market (you will have to be fast), a cityscape from the top of your terrace, the interior of your room, or anything that you want. To capture really memorable images of a monument, for example, take a panorama with the monument in the centre, and a friend in the foreground.

Remember to use the lowest filesize possible for your photos, to save on space in the camera memory and to save a lot of time processing the panorama later on. It is also a safe bet to do two sweeps of the area you want a panorama of, in case you miss out a portion of it. One very important precaution is to set the white balance manually to a constant setting so that you don't have a wide range of brightness across the photographs on the automatic setting. This is particularly important while taking panoramas with the sun in the picture somewhere. Although